



Here Comes SSL VPN

VPNs have already been recognised by enterprises as the preferred medium of connecting globally strewn offices to their intra-networks. Even in India, VPNs are appreciated for offering significant reduction in costs and a secure means of connection. There is a new technology that is also gaining in popularity—SSL VPNs.

Secure Sockets Layer Virtual Private Network (SSL VPN) is an application-independent security protocol. It gives users access to the Web, server and file-sharing resources from Internet cafés, kiosks, wireless devices, or PCs. The SSL protocol is already embedded in most IP (Internet Protocol) stacks. Organisations that deploy SSL VPNs are spared any additional cost. It is ideal for businesses with their personnel always on the move.

The key considerations for evaluating SSL VPN products as a remote access solution are encryption, application support, end-point security and total cost of ownership.

Are VPNs Cost-Effective?

Once a business house sets up a VPN, drastic reduction in infrastructure costs follows. A VPN can extend across geographical boundaries without the use of dedicated leased lines. Says P J Nath, Senior Vice-President, Enterprise Solutions, Sify Limited, “We look at the number of users or networks that the organisation needs, the level of service required in terms of latency, uptime, and how far the organisation wants us to manage the network.”

Abbas feels that it is always safer if an organisation doesn’t get stuck to just one provider. “If my leased line fails or the service provider is down, I can still reach by head office over any other ISP provided bandwidth, and pay only till the time I use it,” Abbas explained.

The money angle aside, security is a big concern.

Firewalls are used to make VPNs secure. Each remote user has a firewall client installed, which filters internal clients from external elements, and cuts down on chances of network disruptions. All the regional offices need to run the network on these two exchange languages, SQL or MS, to be able to decipher the encrypted information.

With firewalls in place, it becomes easy to restrict the number of open ports. Abbas feels that since the data exchanged is not extremely critical, a firewall is good enough for security.

Abbas feels that the kind of security required should be given importance considering the business requirements. Organisations that handle sensitive data should look out for network security. They must use the IPSec (Internet Protocol Security) Protocol and AAA Servers (Authentication, Authorization and Accounting).

The Communications Revolution

For Anglo-Eastern Ship Management Ltd, the change to a VPN has resulted in faster and better Internet speed. With the slash in bandwidth and port charges, the company could do away with leased lines and the mammoth costs they entailed. For the 100-odd employees, a 2 Mbps line is enough to keep in touch with the rest of the offices worldwide. Today, an Anglo-Eastern employee can connect from his home to the VPN without worrying about disruptions.

Says Dean, “The number of hours put in the office doesn’t require any one of us to use this facility from home.” And employees get to enjoy a well-deserved weekend. In sum, a Virtual Private Network cuts down on bandwidth costs for your business, and allows you to stay connected without nightmares about security issues and cyber-threats. ■

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